READING PART 4

Matching headings

Task Overview

In Part 4, you read a longer text divided into 7 paragraphs and match each paragraph to the best heading. There are 8 headings, so one extra does not match any paragraph.

Key points:

- There are 7 paragraphs and 8 headings.
- One heading is extra (not used).
- The key is to identify the main idea of the paragraph.

General strategy

- Read each paragraph for **gist**: "What job is this paragraph doing?" What is the purpose / function of the paragraph.
- If you have time, try to **predict** what you think the heading might be.
- Watch out for **distractors**: Just because the heading contains the same or similar words, it might not match the main idea.
- Under time pressure, focus on the **first and last sentences** to confirm the main point.

In this chapter, you will:

- practise reading paragraphs for gist and function
- learn how to spot plausible distractors
- complete guided tasks and full exam-style practice

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Guided Reading Task

In the following task, we will focus on reading paragraphs for “gist”: this means establishing the **main idea** of the paragraph, and paraphrasing it and understanding its **function**.

The rise of cashless payments

Instructions: Read the passage quickly. Choose a heading for each numbered paragraph (1–7) from the list of headings (A–H). There is one extra heading which you do not need to use.

Step 1: Read the opening paragraph

Read paragraph one, and think about what the **main idea** is, and the **objective** of the paragraph. Try to write your own heading in the box below.

1:

In many countries, paying with cash is becoming less common. Contactless cards, smartphone wallets and online banking have made electronic payment fast and convenient, especially for small everyday purchases. For many consumers, tapping a card or scanning a phone now feels more normal than carrying coins and notes. This change has not happened overnight; it has grown gradually as payment technology has improved and as shops and services have adapted. Even so, the overall direction is clear: in ordinary situations, cash is increasingly treated as a back-up rather than the default option.

Which of these headings best fits this paragraph?

A: **A new way to pay for everyday purchases**

B: **Cashless payments are more convenient**

C: **A shift in everyday habits**

- Which words or phrases in the paragraph support your answer?
- Why are the other two headings not quite right?

Answers and explanations:

A: Incorrect: Mentions payment methods, but the paragraph’s main point is the trend (cash used less), not the methods. (Too narrow.)

B: Incorrect: “Fast and convenient” is a detail; the paragraph mainly describes a gradual change in behaviour. (Wrong focus.)

C: Correct: Evidence: “less common”, “more normal”, “not happened overnight / grown gradually”, “cash… back-up”.

Step 2: Write headings for the other paragraphs

Now read each of the following paragraphs and write your own heading for each of them.

2:

Businesses have helped accelerate this trend. Handling cash involves time, storage, and security risks, and it often requires staff to count money, prepare change, and transport takings safely. Digital payments can reduce queues and make accounting simpler, particularly for high-volume sectors such as cafés, supermarkets and transport systems. For customers, the appeal is speed and convenience, especially when payments are small or repeated. In addition, digital transactions can integrate smoothly with loyalty schemes and receipts, which companies value. From a business perspective, cashless systems can appear more efficient and easier to control.

3:

Nevertheless, a system that depends heavily on technology introduces new vulnerabilities. Electronic payments can fail due to software errors, network problems, power cuts or broader disruptions. There is also the risk of cybercrime, including attacks that target payment providers or customer data. When electronic systems go down, even temporarily, people can find themselves unable to pay for basic goods or services, while businesses may be forced to stop trading. These incidents are usually short-lived, but they highlight a key issue: cash functions without connectivity, whereas cashless payments require infrastructure that is not always guaranteed.

4:

A further concern is inclusion. Not everyone has easy access to banking services, smartphones or reliable internet, and some people rely on cash because it helps them manage spending and avoid debt. For others, cash is essential because they are paid in cash, do not meet bank requirements, or lack confidence with digital tools. If physical money becomes difficult to use, these groups may face extra costs, limited choices, or barriers to everyday activities. Even people who are comfortable with technology may prefer cash in certain situations, such as budgeting, small transactions, or emergencies when systems fail.

5:

Privacy is another point of debate. Cash purchases are largely anonymous, whereas electronic payments create records that can be stored, analysed and sometimes shared between organisations. These records may help prevent fraud and reduce theft, but they also raise questions about who controls personal information and how it is used. Some consumers feel uneasy about the level of insight that payment providers, advertisers or even authorities could gain from detailed spending patterns. The issue is not only surveillance in a dramatic sense, but also a gradual loss of control over personal data, which can be difficult to reverse once systems are widely adopted.

6:

Supporters of cashless systems often argue that the benefits extend beyond individual convenience. Reduced cash use may lower certain types of crime and make it harder to hide income, which can increase tax collection. Governments and financial institutions may also see advantages in efficiency and transparency, as digital payments can be tracked, audited and integrated into wider economic planning. At the same time, critics respond that these benefits do not automatically justify rapid change, particularly if the costs are felt most strongly by vulnerable groups. In this sense, the debate is not only about payment methods, but also about the kind of society people want.

7:

For the moment, many countries appear to be moving towards a mixed system. Cash is still useful in certain contexts, and a significant number of people prefer having a choice, even if they use digital methods most of the time. The challenge is to modernise payment systems while ensuring reliability, fairness and public trust. Policymakers and businesses may need to protect access to cash in some form, while also improving the security and resilience of digital infrastructure. Rather than a simple victory for one method over the other, the likely future is a balance shaped by technology, regulation and public behaviour.

- Now try to match the paragraphs with the headings below.

🚨 Remember, there is one extra heading you do not need.

- How close were your predictions?

A: Risk of leaving people behind

B: Moving towards a middle ground

C: The appeal of efficiency and control

D: The endpoint of physical money

E: Trading anonymity for data

F: The broader societal impact

G: An inherently fragile alternative

H: A shift in everyday habits ✅ **paragraph 1**

Choose the strategy that works best for you!

- I prefer to read the paragraphs first and make careful predictions — this helps to avoid choosing **distractors**.
- If you need to go faster, you can **skim** the headings first to help match them to paragraphs more quickly.
- Under a lot of **time pressure**? Try reading just the first and last sentences of each paragraph.

There is **no one right way**! Whatever works best for you

Practice Reading Task

Now try another task using the same strategies we've just practised!

The role of exams in measuring ability

Instructions: Read the passage quickly. Choose a heading for each numbered paragraph (1–7) from the list of headings (A–H). There is one extra heading which you do not need to use.

1:

For decades, examinations have been treated as the most reliable way to judge academic performance. They offer a single result that can be compared across large numbers of candidates, which is attractive to schools, employers and universities. This apparent clarity has encouraged a belief that exam grades are a simple summary of a person's ability and potential. In reality, however, that assumption depends on what we mean by "ability", and whether a short written test can represent it. Even so, in many education systems, exam results remain the main currency through which achievement is recognised.

2:

One reason exams remain popular is that they appear to be fair. All candidates answer the same questions under the same time limits, in controlled conditions, and the marking process can be standardised. This creates the impression that personal background matters less than performance on the day. In addition, exams are efficient: when resources are limited and decisions must be made quickly—such as admissions or recruitment—they allow institutions to process large numbers of applicants. For systems under pressure, an imperfect but practical tool is often preferred to a more detailed approach that is harder to manage.

3:

Yet this efficiency has a cost. Written exams tend to measure a narrow set of skills, often rewarding those who can process information quickly, stay calm under pressure, and apply familiar formats confidently. Strong exam technique can sometimes make a bigger difference than deep understanding, particularly when students are trained to predict question styles. Meanwhile, candidates who are creative, practical or reflective may be disadvantaged, even if they are capable of high-level work in real-life settings. The result is that exams can reflect a particular type of performance rather than a broad picture of competence.

4:

Exam outcomes can also be influenced by factors that are not directly linked to ability. Stress, sleep, health, and personal circumstances on the day can all affect how well someone performs. Some learners experience an ongoing form of test anxiety that reduces performance even when they are well prepared and knowledgeable. Others may be coping with responsibilities outside school that limit revision time, while still having strong intellectual potential. These influences do not mean exams are useless, but they do suggest that results can be "noisy" measures—accurate for some candidates, less so for others—especially when a single sitting carries high consequences.

5:

Because of these concerns, some educators argue for broader assessment methods that capture performance over time. Coursework, extended projects, presentations and portfolios can show skills that exams struggle to measure, such as planning, collaboration and sustained problem-solving. Supporters claim these approaches reward consistency and a wider set of strengths, rather than a single high-stakes event. They also argue that such tasks resemble real academic or professional work more closely than timed tests do. In theory, this makes assessment feel more meaningful to students and reduces the sense that an entire future depends on one morning in an exam hall.

6:

However, alternatives have their own weaknesses. Coursework can vary greatly between institutions, and it may be difficult to guarantee that work is entirely the candidate's own, particularly when outside help is available. Group tasks can obscure individual performance, and presentations may favour confident speakers rather than those with the strongest ideas. Even where teachers apply clear criteria, differences in expectations and training can affect grades. As a result, broad assessment can become less comparable across schools and regions, and therefore less trusted by institutions that need consistent data. The problem is not that other methods are invalid, but that they introduce different kinds of unfairness.

7:

For this reason, many systems are moving towards mixed models that combine exams with other forms of assessment. The goal is not necessarily to remove exams, but to reduce their dominance and improve reliability by balancing different sources of evidence. Ideally, this approach keeps the efficiency and comparability of exams while also recognising skills that are better demonstrated through extended work. The difficult question is how to design such systems without making assessment overly complex or expensive. In the end, debates about exams often come down to trade-offs: fairness, accuracy and practicality rarely align perfectly, so the "best" solution depends on what a system values most.

A: **Issues with consistency and trust**

B: **The enduring appeal of a single metric**

C: **Towards a compromise**

D: **Factors that can distort results**

E: **A solution that depends on technology**

F: **The merits of standardisation and speed**

G: **A necessarily narrow snapshot**

H: **An attempt to build a fuller picture**

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